

**ASEAN Statement
67th Session of the Commission on Narcotic Drugs
High-Level Segment
March 2024**

Introduction

Madam / Mr. Chairman,

On behalf of the Association of Southeast Asian Nations or ASEAN, I would like to congratulate and welcome Your Excellency as the Chair of the High-Level Segment of the 67th Commission on Narcotic Drugs.

2. ASEAN recognises the importance of the 67th CND since this is also the year when the international community takes stock of our efforts to combat the world drug problem since the 2019 Ministerial Declaration.

3. I now seek the Chair's permission to deliver a statement on behalf of the ASEAN Member States consisting of Brunei Darussalam, Cambodia, Indonesia, Lao People's Democratic Republic, Malaysia, Myanmar, Philippines, Singapore, Thailand and Viet Nam as endorsed during the 8th ASEAN Ministerial Meeting on Drug Matters (AMMD) in August 2023.

World Drug Problem

4. The World Drug Problem is a complex and continuous challenge that undermines the livelihood of communities and the development of countries. According to the World Drug Report 2022, in 2019, an estimated 494,000 deaths were attributable to drug abuse. This is a 17.5% increase since 2009.¹

5. Drug trafficking and abuse also pose a heavy burden on our society because of this strong relationship between drugs and crime. Such criminal activity can be caused by abusers committing crimes to pay for drugs to feed their addiction while others are due to the influence of drugs.

6. We strongly believe that drugs destroy lives and families, and have no place in our societies. For this reason, the ASEAN Member States

¹ World Drug Report 2022

have maintained a zero-tolerance approach against drug, and our leaders have consistently reaffirmed our shared commitment to a Drug-Free ASEAN vision.

7. As reaffirmed in the 2019 Ministerial Declaration, ASEAN Member States reiterate our determination to address and counter the world drug problem and to actively promote a society free of drug abuse in order to help ensure that all people can live in health, dignity and peace, with security and prosperity, and reaffirm our determination to address public health, safety and social problems resulting from drug abuse.

World Drug Policy and Moving Forward

8. In addressing the world drug problem, ASEAN Member States strongly support and reaffirm our continued support to the CND in its role as the principal policy-making body of the United Nations on all matters of international drug control and as the governing body of the UNODC's drug programme so as to combat the spread of drug abuse. Through the CND-led process, we reaffirm our commitments to jointly address and counter the world drug problem in a comprehensive, balanced and integrated manner.

9. ASEAN affirms that the Single Convention on Narcotic Drugs of 1961 as amended by the 1972 Protocol, the Convention on Psychotropic Substances of 1971, and the United Nations Convention against Illicit Traffic in Narcotic Drugs and Psychotropic Substances of 1988, constitute the cornerstone for world drug policy and acknowledges their continued relevance in meeting the challenges we are facing. ASEAN underscores the critical importance of complying with these conventions. ASEAN also notes that current controls do not prevent access to controlled drugs for medical and research purposes.² However, we wish to stress that the use of controlled drugs for medical and research purposes should continue to be based on science and backed by evidence and governed by strict safeguards to prevent abuse or diversion.

Regional Drug Challenges

10. The UNODC reported that in 2021, the number of methamphetamine tablets seized in East and Southeast Asia exceeded

² 1961 International Drug Control Convention Article 2 para 5

one billion tablets. The situation is not expected to improve. But as we deal with current challenges, new ones have also emerged.

11. The COVID-19 pandemic and strict border movements have created opportunities for drug syndicates to innovate and the region saw an increase in novel concealment methods and changes in trafficking routes. According to the ASEAN Drug Monitoring Report 2021, while the number of drug offenders in ASEAN declined slightly during COVID-19 pandemic, seizures in 2021 increased by over 200% since 2019.

12. As use of social media and e-commerce platforms became more common place, drug traffickers have also turned to them and encrypted messaging applications to promote and sell drugs. Additionally, payments made using crypto currencies and orders delivered under false declarations have made it more challenging for law enforcement to detect such illegal activity.

13. We are also mindful that these challenges are linked to other forms of organized crime, including money-laundering, corruption and human trafficking.

ASEAN's Effort in Tackling the Regional Drug Problem

14. Despite the challenges and our diverse drug situations, ASEAN remains resolute in our shared commitment to counter the world drug problem and preserve the rights of our people to live in a safe and secure environment, and lead healthy and meaningful lives. It is also because of this commitment that motivates ASEAN to adopt the theme of "Securing Communities Against Illicit Drugs 2016-2025" for our Work Plan, underpinned by the broader ASEAN Political Security Community vision of a peaceful, stable and resilient region with shared responsibility for comprehensive security. Through this Work Plan, we have seen an increase in greater cooperation between ASEAN Member States and also with external parties such as our Dialogue Partners to combat the illicit drug problem.

15. To improve information sharing among the ASEAN Member States, we have established the ASEAN Narcotics Cooperation Center or ASEAN- NARCO, and subsequently formed the ASEAN Drug Monitoring

Network or ADMN. This network helps to facilitate the sharing of the latest information on regional drug trends via a dedicated sharing platform. In addition, the ASEAN-NARCO publishes the annual ASEAN Drug Monitoring Report, which details and analyses the drug situation within ASEAN and has proven to be a valuable resource in our fight against drugs.

16. Operationally, ASEAN Member States have also grown tighter through the close collaboration of our drug law enforcement agencies. We now have several platforms for intelligence sharing, as well as for coordination of joint operations. For example, the establishment of the ASEAN Airport Interdiction Task Force and the ASEAN Seaport Interdiction Task Force facilitated better information exchanges, thus making it more difficult for drugs to enter our borders for further distribution.

17. On the demand reduction front, we have built an ASEAN portal to share useful resources on preventive drug education while progressively scaling up treatment coverage to include evidence-based interventions and community-based rehabilitation programmes. Our aim is to help drug abuser fully integrate into the society and lead a drug-free life.

18. The ASEAN Member States are strengthening their existing capabilities to sustain Alternative Development (AD) programmes to prevent farmers from returning to illicit crop cultivation and improve their quality of life. We have achieved some success in the reduction of opium poppy cultivation. The Member States also engaged in integrated area development, skills training and income-generating livelihood programmes in both rural and urban settings to further reduce the supply and demand for illicit drugs. We look forward to greater cooperation and collaboration within Member States and internationally on the sharing of experiences and best practices regarding AD programmes.

19. ASEAN recognizes the tireless efforts undertaken by our national authorities in the various fields, including law enforcement, criminal justice, health, and education, with an aim to achieving a society free of drug abuse and Drug-Free ASEAN. Moving forward, we will continue to work together to effectively implement the Work Plan 2016 – 2025.

Conclusion

20. We believe that countering the world drug problem is a shared responsibility and working collectively is integral in combating the drug problem. We also respect the sovereign right of each state to decide and implement policies that best cater to their domestic circumstances as there is no 'one-size-fits-all' approach in addressing the drug issues.

21. We have achieved some encouraging progress in combating the drug scourge thus far but work still remains to be done. ASEAN has demonstrated that by working together as a community, we can send a strong message to international crime and drug syndicates that ASEAN will not allow such organisations to gain a foothold in our region, and to our people and the communities that drug abuse is not acceptable.

22. To this end, we extend our best wishes and cooperation for the 67th CND.

I thank you, Madam Chair / Mr. Chairman.